

Getting Started with MySQL

This appendix gives you what you need to get started with MySQL.

What You Need

To start using MySQL and to follow along with the chapters in this book, you need access to a MySQL server and copies of client applications (software used to access the server).

You do not need your own installed copy of MySQL, but you do need access to a server. You basically have two options:

- Access to an existing MySQL server, perhaps one provided by your hosting company or place of business or school. To use this server, you need to be granted a server account (a login name and password).
- You may download and install a free copy of the MySQL server for installation on your own computer. (MySQL runs on all major platforms, including Windows, Linux, and macOS.)

Tip

If You Can, Install a Local Server For complete control, including access to commands and features that you will probably not be granted if you are using someone else's MySQL server, install your own local server. Even if you don't end up using your local server as your final production DBMS, you'll still benefit from having complete and unfettered access to all that the server has to offer.

Regardless of whether you use a local server, you need client software (the program you use to actually run MySQL commands). The most readily available client software is the `mysql` command-line utility, which is included with every MySQL installation. You should also install the official MySQL UI, MySQL Workbench, which will be the primary tool you use to interact with MySQL.

Obtaining the Software

To learn more about MySQL, go to dev.mysql.com.

To download a copy of the server, go to dev.mysql.com/downloads/. To follow along with this book, it is recommended that you download and install MySQL 5 (or later). The exact download process varies by platform, but it is clearly explained.

MySQL Workbench may not be installed as part of the core MySQL installation. If needed, you can download it from <http://dev.mysql.com/downloads/>.

Installing the Software

If you are installing a local MySQL server, do so before installing the optional MySQL utilities. The installation procedure varies from platform to platform, but all installations prompt you for needed information, including the following:

- The installation location. The default is usually fine.
- The password for the root user.
- Ports, service or process names, and more. As a rule, use default values if you are unsure what to specify.

Tip

Multiple Copies of the MySQL Server Multiple copies of the MySQL server may be installed on a single machine, as long as each of them uses a different port.

Preparing to Read This Book

After you have installed MySQL, you can read Chapter 3, “Working with MySQL,” to see how to log in and log out of the server, as well as how to execute commands.

The chapters in this book all use real MySQL statements and real data. Appendix B, “The Example Tables,” describes the example tables used in this book and explains how to obtain and use the table creation and population scripts.